

is in the sixth column.

INDEX and COUNT functions — for the last cell in a column

Net banking websites provide downloadable spreadsheet files that contain the list of transactions in your account. The last cell in the statement contains your current balance. However, in a financial year, the list of transactions grows and the location of the last cell moves. How can you find the last cell in a column using a formula?

The trick is to use both INDEX and COUNT functions. The INDEX function can use row and column coordinates to obtain a value from a range of cells. The COUNT function can count the number of cells that are not empty.

Using the two functions together, I came to this formula:

```
=INDEX(E7:E16,COUNT(E7:E16),1)
```

To limit the size of the screenshot, I used only a few rows in the example (E7:E16) including blank ones. A typical list of transactions will have hundreds of rows so a much larger range will be required.

Figure 4 shows the function COUNT(E7:E16) returns 8 as the number of rows in the list of transactions. Thus, the INDEX function just needs to go to the 8th cell down from E7 to find the final account balance.

Convert text to columns

If you download your list of transactions from your net banking site as a spreadsheet or CSV, not all cell values may be appropriately converted. It is likely that numbers and dates are all prefixed with a single quote (“ ‘ “) to prevent their values from being converted to illogical values. For example, to prevent a long number 23423234234234 from being converted as an exponential value 234232E+12 (which loses precision as it gets

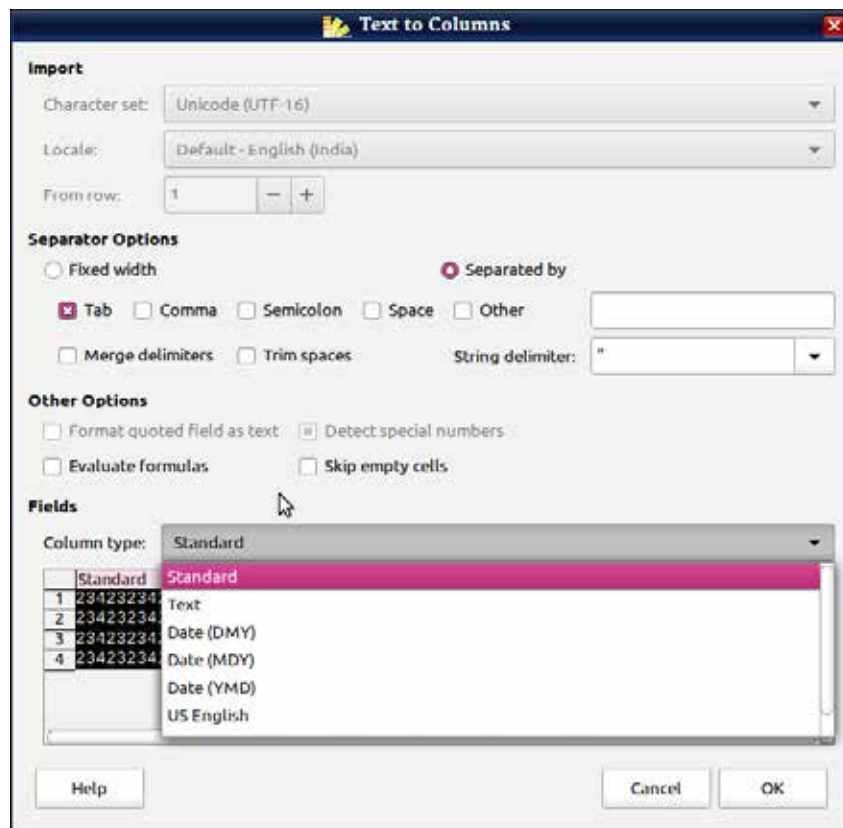


Figure 5: This dialog is not very intuitive. The trick is to first click on the cells preview in the 'Fields' section, which then populates the 'Column type' list with appropriate values. You can then choose the appropriate target cell value type from that list.

rounded off), it may be specified as text as '23423234234234'.

When cell values contain text rather than numbers and dates, you cannot apply formulae on them from other cells. Rather than leave them as they are, you may need to study each set of cells first and convert appropriately. There is a *Text to Columns...* option in the *Data* menu of Calc but it is not very intuitive. It works only on one column at a time. That is, you cannot convert multiple columns at a time. The correct procedure is:

- Select the cells (in a column) that need to be converted to numbers or dates.
- Select *Data » Text to Columns...* from the Calc main menu.
- In the *Text to Columns* dialog that opens up, click on the cells preview in the *Fields* section.

- Choose an option in the *Column type* list, which will now be populated with appropriate target value types for the cells that you have clicked and selected in the previous step.

The bottomline

People who use Excel or Calc everyday may find these functions as nothing out of the ordinary. For someone who has used spreadsheet programs only to sort lists or do simple totals, these conditional functions can seem mind-blowing. **END** 🐧

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